

Career & Goal Planning

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Date filled in: _____

Horizon: _____ to _____

A working worksheet — write in it, cross things out, be honest rather than impressive.

1 THE HOURS I ACTUALLY HAVE

Not the ones I wish I had

List every standing commitment for a normal week this semester — classes, the costume shop, shoots, church, commute, sleep, seeing people you love. Add the hours up before you plan anything. The number at the bottom is the truth you have to build on.

[illegible]

2 MY THREE LANES, TOLD STRAIGHT

Costume · Film · Writing. Fill a column for each. A lane can be excellent and still be the wrong one to push this year — that is what the last row is for.

	COSTUME	FILM	WRITING
What I'm known for <i>now</i>			
Strongest piece of proof I have			
What I want to be known for by 2029			
The weakest link between here and there			
Does it pay yet? Could it?			
Does it feed me or drain me?			
This year: <i>grow / bold / pause</i>			

3 WHAT IS NOT UP FOR NEGOTIATION

Money I must earn, hours I cannot exceed, people and practices I will not sacrifice, health limits. Everything else in this worksheet has to fit around these.

4 FAITH & THE LIFE UNDERNEATH THE WORK

The part no CV has a column for

Career planning tends to assume the work is the point. Fill this in first if you want the rest of the sheet to stay in proportion.

RHYTHM	HONESTLY, RIGHT NOW	WHAT I WANT IT TO BE	WHAT WOULD ACTUALLY MAKE THAT POSSIBLE
Prayer			
Scripture / reading			
Church & community			
Rest / sabbath			
Serving others			
Giving			
Silence, walks, being unproductive			

Who knows the real state of things with me — not the update version?

What do I want my life with God to look like a year from now — described plainly, not piously?

Where am I being asked to trust rather than to strive?

What am I trying to control that is not mine to carry?

Where do faith and craft meet in my work — and where do they pull against each other?

What would I refuse to make, or refuse to make it for? What am I FOR?

5 THE LADDER

Write the far one first, then work down. Each rung should make the one above it more likely.

Five years out — autumn 2031

Where do I live? What does a good Tuesday look like? What am I making, and who am I making it with? What pays for it?

Two years out — autumn 2028, roughly eighteen months after graduation

Three sentences. What is my title, or the honest description of what I do? What is on my reel or in my book? Who knows my name?

Graduation — May 2027. What has to be TRUE by then?

Portfolio, credits, relationships, savings, a place to live, a first job or the runway to look for one. Be specific enough to check off.

WHAT MUST BE TRUE BY MAY 2027	WHY IT MATTERS	TRUE YET? WHAT IS MISSING

This academic year — September 2026 to May 2027

No more than three goals. If everything is a goal, nothing is. Add how you will know each one is DONE, not "worked on."

GOAL FOR THE YEAR	DONE LOOKS LIKE...	FIRST MOVE	BY WHEN

This semester — through December 2026

WHAT I WILL FINISH THIS SEMESTER	WHICH YEAR-GOAL IT SERVES	DEADLINE

This month

This week — three things, no more

If the week goes sideways, which ONE of these still happens?

6 REVERSE-PLAN ONE BIG GOAL

Pick the goal that scares you most and walk it backwards

THE GOAL

WORKING BACKWARDS	WHAT MUST ALREADY BE DONE	WHO OR WHAT I NEED FOR IT
The goal itself		
One month before		
Three months before		
Six months before		
The very next step		

7 GRAD SCHOOL — ENTRY FALL 2027

Most applications close between December 2026 and mid-January 2027. That is THIS semester.

What do I want grad school to give me that two more years of working would not? Be concrete — training, time, a cohort, a credential, access, permission.

What would make me decide NOT to go, or to defer a year? Name it now, before the deadlines start deciding for me.

[illegible]

Letters of recommendation

Ask at least six weeks out. Send each one the deadline, the programme, your résumé, and a reminder of what you did together.

WHO	ASKED?	SENT THEM MY MATERIALS?	DUE

Money: tuition, aid, assistantships, teaching. What debt am I actually willing to take on — a number, not a feeling?

STATEMENT DRAFTED BY _____ LETTERS REQUESTED BY _____

What I have to make

- ☐ Statement of purpose — first draft
- ☐ Statement rewritten for each school
- ☐ Portfolio / lookbook
- ☐ Writing sample — which script?
- ☐ Reel
- ☐ Transcripts requested
- ☐ CV updated
- ☐ Fee waivers checked

If I do not go, or do not get in: what is my Fall 2027 instead? (This is a real plan, not a consolation prize.)

PORTFOLIO FINAL BY	EVERYTHING SUBMITTED BY

8 THE PIPELINE

Nothing happens without submitting, applying, or asking. Keep this page fed.

Types: festival · internship · job · freelance gig · grant / fund · residency · fellowship · grad programme · open call. A healthy pipeline has something in it every month, and most of it will be a no. That is the job.

[illegible]

RENT + BILLS / MONTH	FOOD + TRANSIT / MONTH
EVERYTHING ELSE / MONTH	TOTAL I NEED / MONTH

SOURCE	\$ / MONTH	HOURS IT COSTS	RELIABLE?
TOTAL IN	GAP (+ / -)		

Block the non-negotiables first, then the deep work, then the rest

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Morning							
Midday							
Afternoon							
Evening							

Pick few. A half-learned skill is a hobby; a finished one is a credit.

[illegible]

14 **HOW I DECIDE**

Write the filter now, while nothing is at stake, so you can use it when something is

I say YES when...

I say NO when...

My automatic no-s this year — the things I will stop being talked into:

The last three things I said yes to. Would the filter above have let them through? Should it have?

15 **THE HONEST QUESTIONS**

If I could only work in ONE lane for the next twelve months, which would I pick — and what does that tell me?

What am I doing mostly because someone would be disappointed if I stopped?

What would I attempt this year if I were certain no one would think it was arrogant?

What am I afraid of? Underneath that, what am I actually afraid of?

Fear

What is actually true / what I would do about it

At 30, looking back at this year — what would make me proud of it? What would make me wince?

16 **NEXT FOURTEEN DAYS**

The worksheet is worthless without this part

I WILL...

BY (DATE)

WHO KNOWS I SAID SO

17 MONTHLY CHECK-IN

Ten minutes, first of the month. Same five questions.

1. What moved? · 2. What stalled, and honestly why? · 3. What did I say yes to that I should have declined? · 4. What is the single most important thing for next month? · 5. Who do I need to talk to?

[illegible]

18 ANYTHING I AM NOT READY TO DECIDE YET

Park it here rather than carrying it around

kayleerenaud.com · revisit this whole sheet at the end of each semester — Dec 2026, May 2027